

These aren't hypothetical risks — they're closed federal cases, all triggered by the exact same kind of review reply most practices write without thinking twice.

Every case below is a real HHS Office for Civil Rights settlement, publicly documented. None involved a data breach or a hack — every one started with a well-meaning reply to a Google or Yelp review.

Manasa Health Center — Kendall Park, NJ

\$30,000

Responded to a negative Google review by disclosing a patient's mental health diagnosis and treatment details. OCR's investigation found three additional patients affected the same way.

OCR SETTLEMENT · 2023

Dr. U. Phillip Igbinadolor, D.M.D. & Associates

\$50,000

Civil monetary penalty for disclosing patient information in a public review response.

OCR SETTLEMENT · 2022

New Vision Dental — California

\$23,000

Disclosed patient names and treatment information while responding to Yelp reviews.

OCR SETTLEMENT · 2022

Elite Dental Associates

\$10,000

Settled after disclosing patient information in a response to a single negative Yelp review.

OCR SETTLEMENT · 2019

The federal government has been direct about this: disclosing a patient's information in a public review reply is not a gray area. As one HHS official put it plainly, this "is not allowed."

— Melanie Fontes Rainer, then-Director, HHS Office for Civil Rights

None of these practices intended to violate anything. Every response was written by a staff member trying to defend the practice's reputation — the exact instinct that makes this risk so easy to miss. RespondPal drafts every response specifically calibrated against these patterns, with a human reviewing before anything posts, so this is never something your practice has to get right on its own.